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AHVS 311F

Written Analysis

Omori (2020)

Introduction

Omori is a psychological horror indie RPG, developed by OMOCAT and co-published by Playism on December 25th, 2020. Following an overwhelmingly successful Kickstarter in 2014 (“Omori Wiki”), *Omori* has since amassed significant critical acclaim on *Metacritic* (“Omori”). Embedded with themes of surrealism, trauma, and mental health, this title has been hailed as an example of how games can represent these topics authentically, and destigmatize them in the process (Younis and Fedtke). The following is a written analysis on *Omori*, exploring the many ways it depicts facets of horror within its medium, using notable examples encountered during my fifteen-hour, beginning-to-end playthrough.

Omori follows the story of Sunny, A teenage youth who lives as a *hikikomori*, a Japanese term akin to the word *recluse* in English. Due to his mysterious and traumatic past, Sunny creates worlds in his sleep (e.g., Headspace, White Space, and Black Space), and exists within them as his alter-ego: Omori (“Omori Wiki”). Over the course of three in-game days, the player takes on two primary roles: Playing as Omori during the night within Headspace, and playing as Sunny during the day in Faraway Town (i.e., the real world). In Headspace, Omori travels with childhood versions of his closest friends (Kel, Aubrey, and Hero) in search of their missing friend Basil, supported by Mari (Sunny/Omori’s older sister) every step of the way. In Faraway

Town, this friend group has long been abandoned for reasons initially unknown to the player, pushing Sunny to reconnect with them all before he moves away. Ultimately, players venture through both of these narratives to uncover the sole traumatic event responsible for the creation of Headspace, Sunny's broken friendships, and his fragmented mental health.

Horror Through Depth

In the genre of horror games, one notable way that terror is evoked is through instilling a *fear of depths*, or a *call of the void* within the player. As discussed by Jacob Geller, the call of the void is a psychological phenomenon where one experiences fear of the depths below, while simultaneously feeling driven toward it (Jacob Geller). In essence, it is the feeling one gets when staring over the edge of a cliff, knowing they are one step away from the fall. It is a form of horror that both repels and attracts us.

Omori exemplifies this aspect of horror through the use of its environments. Consider the starting area of the game, where the player wakes up as Omori in White Space. This place, created in Sunny's mind, is a void white room, with infinitely expanding walls and ceilings—featuring a minimally decorated living space kept for Omori to exist in. Given this, White Space's endless emptiness can be considered a form of depth. Though Omori is technically safe from all danger within White Space, the player will begin to feel that White Space is virtually impossible to escape due to its infinite volume. As explained by Younis and Fedtke: "Players may find themselves growing restless as they continually wander beyond the confines of the room only to be met with desolate and bare space before promptly being teleported back to the room." (Younis and Fedtke) Through this, *Omori* effectively evokes a fear of depths, or a call to the void, within the player.

Horror Through Phobia: Fear of Heights

Psychological horror games often aim to highlight the emotional and psychological states of the protagonists, as a means of invoking fear within the player (Marak 58). Frequently, these games “emphasize the memories, fears or anxieties of the characters, involving events and enemies which are symbolically significant” (58). In essence, psychological horror games trigger fear within its protagonists, in order to trigger fear within the player.

Omori heavily demonstrates this concept by forcing Sunny to face his deepest phobias. A strong example is found roughly one hour into the game, when Sunny is forced to face his fear of heights. In this sequence, Sunny is seen waking up at home in the middle of the night. From there, the player moves Sunny to the upper hallway, where they encounter a grossly elongated staircase. Feeling as if somehow drawn toward it, they slowly descend down each step. Soon, shadowy and misshapen hands form near the bottom of the staircase. Then, out of nowhere: Shadows of photorealistic hands swarm Sunny. This triggers a turn-based battle sequence, in which your enemy is revealed to be...*Something* (indeed, that is its name). *Something*, also known as “Fear of Heights,” is nebulous to describe (“Omori Wiki”). It presents specific features, such as a twisted smile that floats manically in the air. During the fight, Sunny is hopeless and visibly petrified—conveying a sense of dread that inevitably sinks its teeth into the player. Sunny attempts to stand his ground, but his attacks do no damage. Suddenly, he hears a voice, encouraging him to slow down and breathe. It is here where Sunny learns the ability to *Calm Down*. Through this newly unlocked game mechanic, the player grows able to win the battle against *Something*. In the process, Sunny overcomes his fear of heights, which unlocks more of the world for him to explore (ironically rendering him less of a *hikikomori*—combating

two phobias at once). The key takeaway is this: Through the lens of phobia, *Omori* effectively triggers fear within Sunny, to trigger fear within the player.

Addressing Ethical Issues in Gaming: The Mechanic of Choice in Psychological Horror

As discussed by Brathwaite and Sharp, a game's given mechanics will ultimately convey an intended core message to the player (323). They hold the potential to “frame the particulars of the human experience in strikingly clear ways without necessarily implying a single correct interpretation” (323). Given this, it is important that games—especially horror games surrounding mental illness—address these topics ethically, in a way where the player has access to multiple perspectives. In essence, for psychological horror games to depict mental illness wholly and authentically, they must provide the player with *choices* that will allow them to experience all of its facets.

In poetic fashion, *Omori* ethically addresses these themes through its game mechanics. In particular, *Omori*'s game mechanics feature multiple narrative routes and endings; all of which can be accessed depending on choices made by the player. Arguably, the most notable choice must be made near the end, when Omori themselves strikes down Sunny, forcing a *game over* state for the player. But then, to the player's surprise, they are presented with a yes-or-no choice:

Do you want to continue?

If the player chooses yes, Sunny will ultimately erase Omori, and wake up to find himself in a hospital bed. He will reunite with his friends, and reveal to them his trauma—the secret responsible for all the main events of the narrative: How he killed Mari, his own sister, by accident. The reactions from Sunny's friends are intentionally unshown to the player. Instead, the

game ends with an image of a car driving away; the camera facing out the window. This ending emphasizes the possibility of one overcoming their trauma, and allowing themselves to move on.

If the player chooses no, *Omori* will take full control of Sunny's psyche, and bring him to the edge of the hospital balcony. As the credits roll, Sunny can be seen falling from the building, before the screen cuts to black. This ending, while psychologically horrific in nature, emphasizes the unfortunate possibility of one succumbing to their trauma.

While other variations in choice and narrative are present throughout *Omori*, these two main endings exemplify how a game can use psychological horror to ethically address sensitive themes. Through the mechanic of narrative choice, players are given access to multiple perspectives on trauma and mental illness, without feeling pushed toward a single correct takeaway. They can choose to view the best case or worst case scenarios, as well as other various outcomes in between—a spectrum of perspectives. Thus, *Omori* proves itself to be a raw, poetic psychological horror game, and a driving force for mental illness destigmatization.

Word Count: 1,327

Notable Images

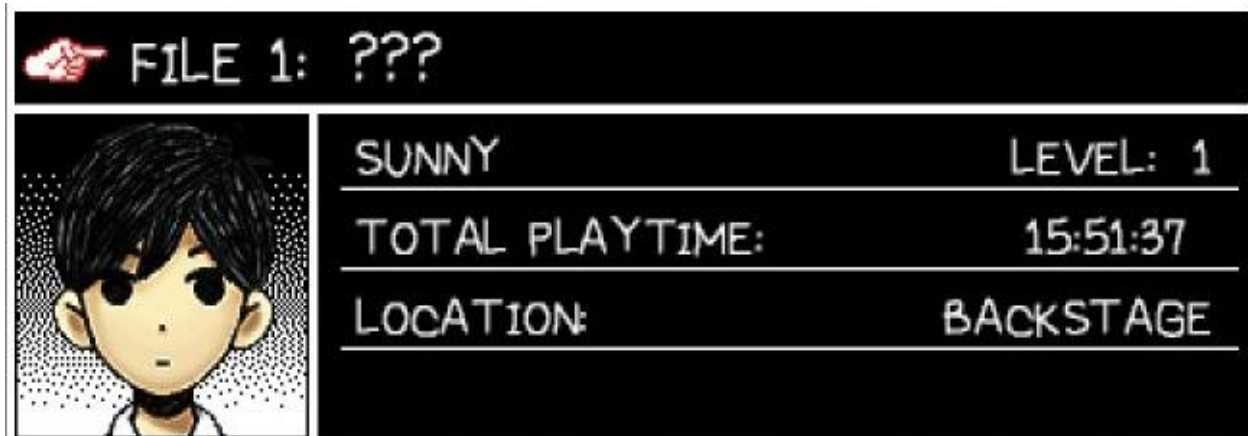


Fig 1. "Robbie's Save Data – Narrative Complete (Good Ending)" OMOCAT LLC, *Omori*, 2020.



Fig 2. "Something – Fear of Heights (Battle Sequence)" OMOCAT LLC, *Omori*, 2020.

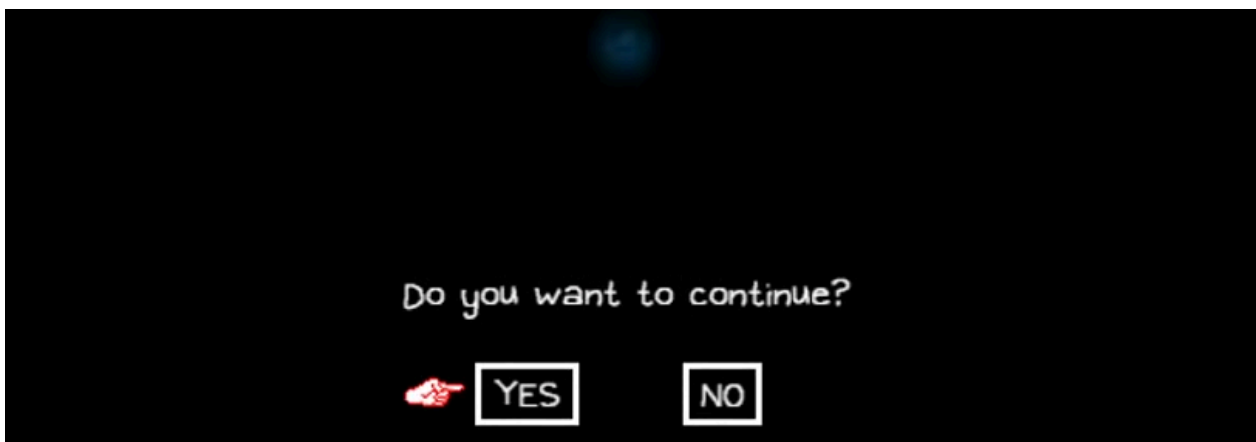


Fig 3. "Game Mechanic – Narrative Choice" OMOCAT LLC, *Omori*, 2020.

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